who are not under the influence of, or dependent upon, Islamabad, should be India's natural partners according to the partisans. Conciliators on the other hand argue that India should focus on whoever comes to power in Kabul without fear or favour. Building goodwill among the people of Afghanistan and politically engaging with every entity, including the Afghan Taliban and its various factions, is the way forward. Highly pragmatic, conciliators believe that non-engagement with factions dependent on Pakistan is not a viable option for India. While the final decision of whom Kabul wants to reconcile with is a decision that only Afghans can take, conciliators are not opposed like the partisans are if Kabul talks with groups New Delhi views as vehemently anti-India. Such a conciliatory approach was visible when New Delhi accepted Karzai's outreach to hardline Taliban elements in the final years of his presidency. The commonalities between the partisans and the conciliators is that both view Pakistan as a source of instability in Afghanistan, neither wants Afghanistan to be strategically dependent on Islamabad, and both reject a political process where Kabul does not influence the terms of talks (at least to an extent).

Apart from delineating policy advocacies, the ACF also helped assessing how and why partisans and conciliators influenced India's Afghanistan policy at different points in time. Their debate was driven by three core and intertwined factors such as (a) striking a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, (b) international political posture towards Afghanistan, and (c) domestic Afghan politics. How these sources of policy change interact with each other determined whether the conciliators or the partisans influenced India's Afghanistan policy. In December 1979 India's strategic dependence on the Soviet Union undermined genuine neutrality, whereas Najibullah's fall in April 1992, which occurred in light of India's economic woes and the disintegration of the Soviet Union, pushed the conciliators to the fore. By 1996, regional actors such as Iran and Russia had reemerged as credible partners to counter the rise of the Taliban that had Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE's support. The US-led NATO intervention in 2001 allowed India to continue with its partisan approach. However, Afghanistan's changing domestic politics paved the way for conciliators to orchestrate tactical shifts in India's approach towards reconciliation after 2010. Equipped with better knowledge and economic resources, India underwent